BALANCE OF POWER

European history has experienced long periods when actual large-scale conflict did not take place. The chief reason behind this was the absence of one single sovereign authority and presence of many sovereign states, each zealously guarding its autonomy. Power was distributed in such a way that each state was able to balance the others. In theory, if any state tried to increase its power, thereby posing a threat, all the others would unite to prevent it. This was what came to be known as the *balance of power* (see Figure 4.1).

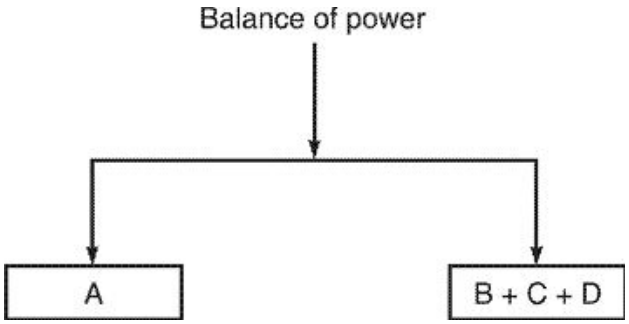


Figure 4.1 Illustration of balance of power.

The basic assumption is that, as long as power is not abolished, it must be met by countervailing power. To rely on the goodwill of powerful neighbours would be naive and only matching power can provide adequate protection under all circumstances. *Mutual deterrence* becomes the buzzword. Any potential aggression is deterred by the potential combined powers of all the other states. Therefore, in such a case, balancing power, either by one single nation or by a group of nations, will prevent any one particular nation from imposing its will upon others. If state A increases its power, state B must try to equalize it. If B alone cannot match A's might, it can join other states and together they can offset the power of A.

The balance of power that existed in Europe during the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries are classic examples of balance of power systems. The focus was not on matching a rival's power by building up one's army but by forming a coalition of one or more other states threatened by the growing power of the rival. Thus, deterrence was achieved by alliances and not by arms races. Historically, under this kind of balance of power systems, there was no increase in the